Lottery winners

Hi everyone, and welcome! This is episode thirteen of the Cottongue Podcast.

[00:00:14] Welcome to this new episode. I hope you're well, I hope you're feeling fit. As I said, this is the twelfth episode, which means I started the Cottongue Podcast three months ago. I'm very happy because there are more and more listeners, so I hope this podcast motivates you to learn French and that I can help you a little in that direction. I hope I can help you achieve your goals.

[00:00:54] What's the weather like where you live? Because where I live, in Warsaw, Poland, the weather is wonderful right now! There's lots of sunshine and temperatures are quite high, between twenty-five and thirty degrees Celsius. So it's really great. We can cycle, walk around and enjoy the city. Warsaw is very pleasant in summer because it's easy to walk around and there are many parks and places to visit. So it's a place, a city, I recommend visiting if you have the opportunity one day.

[00:01:47] Perhaps you've seen I launched a Facebook page simply called Cottongue. On this page, I share advice to help you improve your French, little secrets and techniques. For example, the first technique I discussed was setting your mobile phone to French. You probably use your phone in your mother tongue. That's natural, the easiest option. But if you set it to French, you can learn very useful vocabulary in a fairly natural way. For example, you can memorise verbs such as "send" and "receive", "cancel", "delete" and so on. Setting your phone to French is very easy, and normally possible on any mobile. Just go into the settings, choose the language, and choose French, quite simply. On my Facebook fan page, "Cottongue", you'll see a short video explaining how. In this video, you'll also see that doing this lets you learn weather vocabulary, for example, through the weather application. Or you can memorise dates. I know sometimes we tend to forget the months of the year, January, February, March, April and so on. But if you set your phone to French, every day you'll see the date on the screen, so unconsciously you'll memorise this vocabulary. That's the kind of advice I give on the fan page, but I also share videos, for example, or things I find interesting that can help you learn French. So I invite you to look at this Facebook page to access all this content.

[00:04:34] That's all for self-promotion. Now we'll move on to today's subject.

[00:04:48] In podcast number three, I believe, we talked about happiness. For example, we discussed countries where people are happiest. We often associate happiness with money. We think that if we want to be happy, it's better to have money. Today, we'll talk about people who have won a lot, a lot of money, but in a somewhat exceptional way, because these people became rich by playing the lottery. Perhaps you've heard of "loto". I'm sure it exists in your country. In French, "loto" is the name for the national lottery. A lottery is simply a game of chance. You just buy a ticket to participate, then have a chance to win a lot, a lot of money, millions of euros. Loto is France's most popular game of chance. To play, as I said, you must buy a ticket and choose six numbers on it. In Europe, in the European Union, there's also a lottery called EuroMillions. Obviously, you can win even more money because there are more participants. That's logical. In France, a loto ticket costs €2.20, and you can then win the jackpot, but generally you have a one-in-110-million chance of winning it. In French, the jackpot is also called the "gros lot", the top prize. You should know the

French record, the largest jackpot won, was 169 million euros. Can you imagine such a sum?! I think most of us find it difficult to imagine that amount of money: 169 million euros!

[00:07:46] Do you play games of chance? Do you sometimes play the lottery or other games to win money? Perhaps you sometimes go to a casino to play roulette or blackjack. I do from time to time. Sometimes I buy a lottery ticket when there's a lot of money at stake, a lot to win, but unfortunately I've won only once. Do you know how much I won? Four euros! Well, that isn't much, not really the beginning of a fortune, but it's the most I've managed to win so far. I'm not very superstitious, meaning I don't believe in luck or destiny. Being superstitious means having superstitions. For example, thinking Friday the thirteenth is a special day, unlike other days. Or thinking black cats bring bad luck. I don't believe that at all, precisely because I have two black cats, female cats, to be more precise. I've had them for about a year and think they bring good luck rather than bad. What other examples of superstitions are there? Some people believe breaking a mirror brings several years of bad luck, that bad things will happen for several years. Or they think we must never walk under a ladder, because that too brings bad luck.

[00:10:14] Unfortunately, winning the lottery isn't easy. I told you the chance, the probability, is very, very small. These games can also lead to addictions. We can become addicted to gambling. There's a very famous book by the Russian writer Dostoevsky called *The Gambler*. It concerns a man who gambles a lot of money in casinos and unfortunately tends to lose. Even after losing almost all his money, he can't stop because he's become completely addicted to gambling. He has a gambling addiction. This book also has an autobiographical dimension because Dostoevsky himself was a great casino enthusiast.

[00:11:27] But let's return to our subject. "Revenons à nos moutons", as we say in French. Literally "let's return to our sheep", this idiom means "let's return to the subject that interests us". So let's return to our subject. Have you ever dreamed of playing the lottery? Have you ever wondered what you'd do with the money? Perhaps you'd buy a big car or a beautiful house by the sea, take a long trip with all your friends, or move to a paradise island. But be careful: winning the lottery doesn't always mean a dream life. Some winners have found themselves in very delicate situations afterwards. That's precisely today's subject: lottery winners and what winning brought them, but also the problems they must face, the problems confronting them.

[00:12:54] OK, are you ready to talk about lottery winners? Yes? Then here we go!

[00:13:11] In France, a company organises the lottery, loto. It's called La Française des Jeux, FDJ, Française des Jeux. It's a public company, meaning it's managed by the state, and generally organises all games of chance and games involving money bets. Betting money is giving money in exchange for a chance to win much more. For example, we can bet on horse races. So La Française des Jeux organises all these games. For big winners, meaning people winning more than a million euros, a special team is responsible for supporting, helping and looking after them.

[00:14:27] For example, this team organises meetings at company headquarters with psychologists and advisers who talk to winners and give advice. Of course, advice on managing and investing their money well, but also psychological advice to help them in everyday life and warn them about the problems they'll face.

[00:15:07] Of course, having financial advisers to know how to invest your money is very important. Unfortunately, some winners have spent all their winnings, even more than they won, and ultimately ended up ruined. After a few years, instead of being rich, they were ruined, poor, and also had enormous debts. This is quite bad for the lottery's image, so naturally La Française des Jeux tries to advise winners well so they won't be ruined a few years later.

[00:16:05] But another very important thing is psychological support, psychological help for winners. We might wonder why people who've won the lottery need psychological support, what psychological problems they have. Well, winning the lottery is a radical life change. We can even call it an upheaval. An upheaval is a radical change that changes everything. Why is it an upheaval? Because most lottery winners previously came from rather modest backgrounds, meaning they didn't have much money. Overnight, they find themselves with millions and millions of euros. Naturally, their life is completely different, and adapting to this new situation can be difficult.

[00:17:25] Generally, they go through several stages. The first, of course, is euphoria. That means winners are extremely happy, extremely pleased to have won. They may jump for joy, dance, shout and cry. You can easily imagine the scene: if you won several million euros yourself, you'd probably have a euphoric reaction.

[00:18:01] Then the second stage, for some winners, is a period of anxiety. Anxiety is very great fear. Some winners think of all the changes to come and are terrified. They don't know what their life will become and tend to feel afraid.

[00:18:30] After that, some winners go through a phase of denial. They refuse to believe they've won and try to convince themselves nothing has changed and they haven't won the lottery. But gradually, winners manage to adapt, accept this change and understand their life will change positively.

[00:19:12] What different problems do lottery winners encounter? First, of course, family problems. Winning can create jealousy, especially because other family members sometimes think this money isn't legitimate, isn't deserved. They think lottery winners haven't worked for it. If they haven't worked, it's a little unfair for them to become rich overnight while other family members remain in the same situation. Sometimes the family thinks winners have an obligation to share their winnings. Since the money wasn't earned through work, everyone should benefit. Winners then have to give presents constantly, and gradually these presents are considered obligations. They feel obliged to give gifts to share their winnings. Sometimes others think it's never enough: the gifts aren't expensive or beautiful enough. Occasionally, distant relatives also come asking for money. Perhaps an uncle we haven't seen for years has debts and decides to visit to ask for money. Knowing how to react can be difficult. Who should receive money, and in what form? Should we give presents or cash? It's difficult to know.

[00:21:38] There are also problems with children. Some winners decide not to tell their children they've won. Why? They think if they tell them, the children won't want to make efforts at school, study or succeed in life. They'll simply think they'll never need to work because of their parents' money. It can indeed be difficult for parents to pass on the value of effort. If children know millions of euros await them in a bank account, they probably won't

really want to work hard at school. But at the same time, lying to their children, hiding something like this, is complicated for parents. This too can cause problems for winners.

[00:23:02] Besides family and children, winners often find it difficult to maintain good relationships with friends. Their lifestyle becomes completely different. Perhaps they move to a larger house in a nicer neighbourhood. Perhaps they holiday very often and eat at the best restaurants. With this new lifestyle, we can drift away from friends. “To drift away” means putting distance between ourselves and our friends. Friends too may be jealous of winners. Again, there’s the question of whether the money is legitimate. Friends may think we don’t deserve it. Of course, we might think it’s enough to invite friends on holiday or to restaurants and pay for everything, but some people find always being treated embarrassing. A hierarchical relationship develops, a kind of hierarchy between friends because their material circumstances are no longer the same. Winners also find it difficult to know whether friends appreciate their personal qualities, their personality, or only their money. We may think people are trying to take advantage, that they’re dishonest. Sometimes we can even become a little paranoid. So generally, remaining friends with people whose material circumstances are completely different from ours is difficult.

[00:25:15] Besides these relationship problems, there are more concrete problems concerning adaptation to this new lifestyle. The first question that comes to mind if we win is, “Will I keep working?” For many people, of course the answer is no! Becoming rich, they immediately decide to leave work. But without work, we may also risk boredom. Once we’ve been on holiday, travelled around the world, we may be at home in our big house, beautiful cars parked outside, and realise we’re bored, have nothing to do and no longer want to do anything. We may think life has lost some meaning. To solve this, some people create foundations or charities. That way, they can use their money for a good cause, a good reason, to try to help others. That can give our lives meaning.

[00:26:47] But perhaps the hardest thing for lottery winners is that others think they no longer have the right to have problems or worries. When we’re rich, others think all our problems have disappeared. But that isn’t always true. You know money doesn’t buy happiness, nor does it protect against health problems, for example. So for all these people, the main question becomes, “How can we give our lives new meaning, and enjoy this money in a healthy, reasonable way?”

[00:27:49] That’s the end of this podcast. Thank you for listening. I hope it made you think a little. What would you do if you won the lottery? Would you take a long trip? Buy beautiful cars or a big house? Tell me. I’m interested. I’d like to know what you’d do. Personally, I think I’d travel around the world. That means visiting many countries around the world. Afterwards, I’d open an animal shelter. I love animals and would like to use this money to help them, to come to their aid. I think that would give me great pleasure and make me feel useful. But don’t worry: even if I win the lottery one day, I’ll keep making podcasts to help you learn French, because that also gives me great pleasure!

[00:29:22] Thank you, everyone, for listening, for following this new podcast. I hope you enjoyed it.

[00:29:33] Next week, in the next podcast, make sure you join me, because I’ll give you the recipe for creating a perfect hero. A film hero, for example, or a novel’s hero. So if you’re interested in cinema, join me next week. Thank you, and see you soon!